2.3 Resistance in the South

Terror is a powerful weapon. When combined with racism, its damage can last for generations. A reign of terror in the South set back African-American political gains and broke the Republican Party's hold in the region.

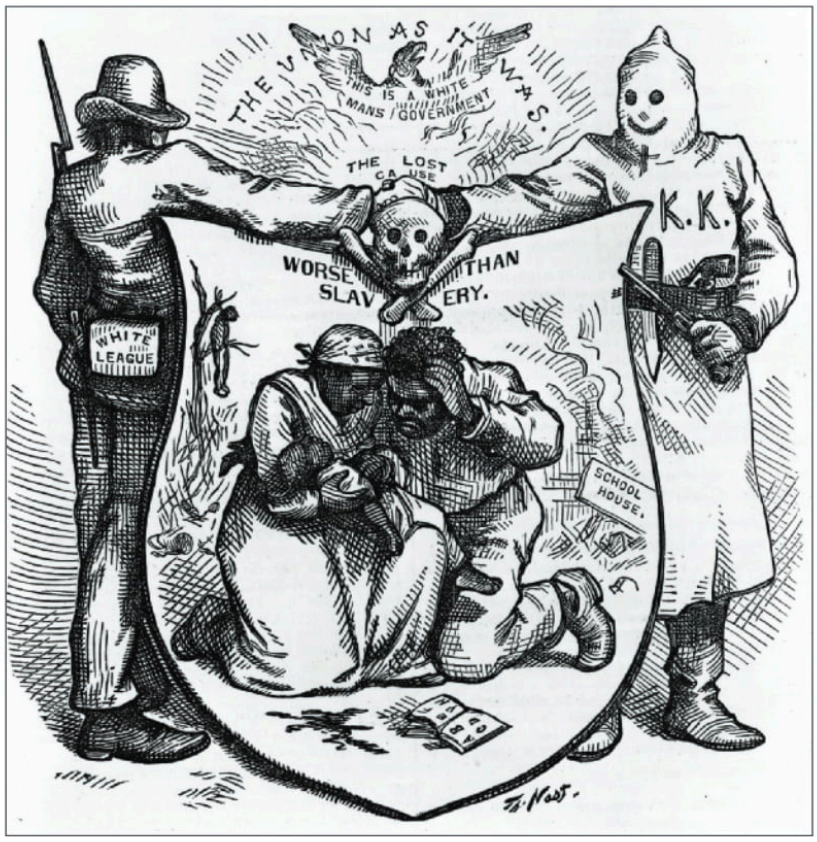
MAIN IDEA Afraid of losing political and economic power, some white southerners used terror tactics against African Americans and Republicans.

THE KU KLUX KLAN

Radical Reconstruction angered many white southerners and created a resistance movement based on racism and discrimination. Few white southerners accepted African Americans as their equals. Sometimes whites turned to violence in an attempt to keep African Americans from voting and exercising other rights. In 1866, white mobs attacked unarmed African-American men, women, and children and rioted in Memphis, Tennessee, and New Orleans, Louisiana. The mobs killed or injured many African Americans. In Memphis, the rioters, who included police officers, committed **arson** by purposefully burning homes, churches, and schools in African-American communities.

That same year, a group of young men in Tennessee founded the **Ku Klux Klan**. Originally intended as a social club, the group's purpose changed dramatically in 1867 when African Americans gained voting rights in the state under the Reconstruction Acts and began holding public office. Thereafter, the Ku Klux Klan, under the leadership of former Confederate officer Nathan Bedford Forrest, dedicated itself to maintaining the social and political power of white people.

To achieve its goals, members of the Klan terrorized and killed African Americans. They also attacked white people who associated with Republicans or supported African-American rights. To conceal their identities and maximize the terror, Klan members rode out at night dressed in hooded costumes. They whipped, tar-and-feathered, and even **lynched**, or hanged, their victims. They also committed arson. The Klan became the face of violent discrimination, carrying out punishments against people whom they felt had overstepped racial boundaries. Boosted by popular sentiment and federal acceptance, the Klan's popularity quickly spread across the South and even beyond.



CRITICAL VIEWING In 1874, this political cartoon by Thomas Nast appeared in *Harper's Weekly*. Why do you think the cartoonist included the words "worse than slavery" over the heads of the African-American family?

Copyright 2025 Cengage Learning. All Rights Reserved. May not be copied, scanned, or duplicated, in whole or in part. Due to electronic rights, some third party content may be suppressed from the eBook and/or eChapter(s). Editorial review has deemed that any suppressed content does not materially affect the overall learning experience. Cengage Learning reserves the right to remove additional content at any time if subsequent rights restrictions require it.



The Klan Through the Years

The Ku Klux Klan members in this photo traveled from New Jersey to take part in a Klan parade held in Washington, D.C., in 1926. The legal action brought against the Klan in 1871 drove its members into hiding, but it did not destroy the organization. Further actions by the government never succeeded in dissolving the group either. The Klan resurfaced in the 1920s, fueled by the arrival of immigrants whom they accused of taking jobs away from "real" Americans.

The Klan began to grab newspaper headlines once again as the civil rights movement gathered momentum in the 1950s and 1960s. After three civil rights volunteers were killed in Mississippi in 1964, FBI agents discovered the murderers were Klan members and police officers. Seven men were arrested for the murders. The Klan still exists today, although it is widely despised and wields very little political power. As of April 2014, official Klan groups were registered in 41 states with a total of as many as 8,000 members.

A POWER SHIFT

In response, the Republican-dominated Congress passed the Enforcement Acts in 1870 and 1871. The acts made it a crime to use violence or threats to interfere with a citizen's right to vote, hold office, or serve on a jury. The acts authorized the federal government to supervise congressional elections and gave the president the power to enforce the acts. The intent of the acts was to stop Klan activities and protect African-American rights.

Armed with the Enforcement Acts, the federal government took legal action against the Klan in 1871. In state after state, the government charged Klan leaders with crimes. The Klan became less visible, but their scare tactics had already damaged the Republican Party by preventing African Americans from voting. As a result, the Democratic Party began to gain back control in the South, and the number of African-American officeholders fell dramatically.

Meanwhile, many white voters in the North also thought the Radical Republicans had gone too far in promoting African-American rights. Even though the country would elect a Republican president in 1868, Reconstruction was starting to lose steam.



Members of the Ku Klux Klan often wore metal membership badges like these. The 1921 Klan badge on the right is shaped like the hood Klan members wore to scare and intimidate their victims.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** What tactics did the Ku Klux Klan use to terrorize African Americans and white Republicans?
2. **MAKE INFERENCES** Why do you think the Klan's activities were allowed to continue in the South until 1870?
3. **SUMMARIZE** How did Klan activities change the balance of political power in the South?

Copyright 2025 Cengage Learning. All Rights Reserved. May not be copied, scanned, or duplicated, in whole or in part. Due to electronic rights, some third party content may be suppressed from the eBook and/or eChapter(s).
Editorial review has deemed that any suppressed content does not materially affect the overall learning experience. Cengage Learning reserves the right to remove additional content at any time if subsequent rights restrictions require it.